New Caregivers Start This Week: The First Three Things to Do So They Know Your Wife

Three first moves, in order, and what can be left for later.

The new caregivers start in a few days. They'll have your wife's chart. They won't have the tea she takes before anything else, or the name she likes to be called.

Three things come first, in this order. The rest of the list can follow.

1 Ask her which routines matter most right now

Sit down with your wife for ten minutes when she's rested. Ask what a good day looks like for her, and which parts of her day she most wants kept the same through this change. Write down what she says in her own words. If she tires, stop and pick it up later. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The page is about her, so she goes first. What she tells you decides what the page says.

2 Put the few most useful details on one short page

Choose the handful of things a new caregiver could use on the first day: what she likes to be called, how her morning and evening go, what she likes and dislikes. One short line each. If a clinician has told you about an allergy or a diet, put it under its own heading, apart from her preferences. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A page that can be read in two minutes gets read on a busy first day. Stopping at a handful also keeps this a first-day note. The fuller picture comes later.

3 Find out who will receive it

Ask the new team who should get the page and who will read it. Give it to that person, introduce yourself as well as her, and ask them to let you know they have it. Write down the name and the date. [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The page helps once it's with the people who are with her. A name also gives you someone to go back to when something changes.

What can be left for later

- The rest of her story: where she was born, her work, the family stories. All worth sharing, in time.
- A complete list of every preference. The first page is the handful that matter on day one.
- Anything you're not sure she'd agree with. Mark it “not confirmed” and leave it for now.
- How her routines will fit around her care. That's a conversation with the new team once they've met her.

What stays with her clinicians

An allergy or a diet a clinician has prescribed is an instruction. It isn't a preference, and your page doesn't replace the written instructions the care team works from. Keep those notes apart, with who gave each one, and take anything you can't place to her doctor or nurse.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't write the page for you, turn any of her preferences into a care instruction, or decide what she would want. It puts the first three moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked her, written a few lines and found out who will read them. The care interview takes it from there: it asks about her preferences across every part of the day, alongside her care needs and the support around her, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The good-day question and the advice to stop when she tires follow The Conversation Project's workbook. The kinds of detail worth sharing follow the Alzheimer's Association's page on working with care providers, which was written for families living with dementia; we use only its general point, and nothing here assumes anything about your wife's health. Introducing yourself along with her follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's advice on a move into residential care. The order is ours.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
2. Alzheimer's Association, Working with Care Providers
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Caregiving Doesn't End When Your Loved One Moves